

The Feather TOUCH

This collection of erotic short stories offers a feisty bag of tricks for even a jaded libido

By Brinda Bose



**ELECTRIC
FEATHER**

Edited by
RUCHIR JOSHI
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And yes I said yes I will Yes." These are the words that end what is, arguably, one of English literature's most erotic passages in the breathless last lines of *Ulysses*: simple, as Molly Bloom was at soul, and yet complex, as James Joyce was formidably known to be. Indeed, fiction in English can boast of an impressive inheritance in the line of 'sex(y)-writing' way back from Chaucer's *Wyf of Bath*, at least. And yet, there has been in general a deplorable lack of brave literary erotica from the South Asian English stable. At last, however, that horse appears to have decamped in staggeringly wild abandon. So now hold on tight for what might well be the most electrifyingly salacious romp that you could abandon yourself to this season: a first-of-its-kind agglomeration of South Asian English erotic short stories, edited by Ruchir Joshi.

It might be best to get the disclaimer out of the way first. As with almost any anthology of short

fiction, single- or multi-authored, not all the stories in *Electric Feather* are uniformly riveting. Of course, the responsibility for this unevenness of quality (and consequently, for providing pleasure—in reading, imaging, imagining) may be laid at the door of its multiplicity: of authorship, stories, stylistics, intentions. Or, it may be wondered whether a pressure to perform actually stymied the act for some, ironically enough much in the same vein as the act itself, that act—of sex, lust, love, desire... call it what you will—and its precedent, concomitant, subsequent and related effects which the writers are commandeered (or cajoled?) to capture in risible prose. That said...

Joshi's introduction is a delight. Inspired to "repair Brindavan", as he puts it, through fiction. He sent out a call to South Asian writers in English for stories which would halt the "denudation" of that space within oneself which is metaphorically an "ancient subcontinental psychic forest of erotic freedom"—now subject, he rues, to a "double rape" by hard porn on the one hand and by fundamentalist forest-fire-lighting by the forces of high morality on the other. Responses to his somewhat quixotic challenge ranged from curiosity to shock, but clearly there were enough intrepid takers to fill up *The Tranquebar Book of Erotic Stories* with not just a gush of sex-for-the-sake-of-sex-writing, but—at their best—a compelling compendium of those emotions and reactions that sex invariably foments: love and longing, passion, pleasure, humour, tenderness, sensuality, satiation, and/or, dissatisfaction, despair, hurt, anger, violence, grief. What turns the book—and its pages—is that it is smart, sophisticated, funny, quirky, poignant and touching, in turn and sometimes all at once.

It is not enough to explain away the allure of such a collection by insisting that sex sells. While this is generally true, it is also commonly known that sex writing constitutes some of the most difficult pages for a writer to sneak past a reader, and more often than not, heroic attempts turn embarrassingly limp. In such a scenario, *Electric Feather* offers a feisty bag of tricks for even a jaded libido. Samit Basu, who kicks off the anthology, tells a deceptively simple tale of secrets and seductions with a provocative twist of tail, so to speak. "People always get really

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